

WALLA WALLA

Union~Bulletin

Thursday,
January 1,
2026 • \$2

WE BRING THE VALLEY TO YOU

Top 10
stories of 2025

A year in review
by the Walla Walla
Union-Bulletin

WALLA WALLA UNION-BULLETIN STAFF

The Walla Walla Valley reached several significant milestones in 2025. Walla Walla County saw the election of its first woman Superior Court judge, the closure of a 3-year-old case involving the shooting of a Washington State Patrol trooper and one final season of commercial strawberry picking by a legacy business. The year saw local traditions resurrected, some ended or strained, and new ones forged. Student athletes brought home hard-fought titles, and parents and teachers rallied to save a school district at risk of dissolution.

Here's a list, in no particular order, of 10 news events selected by the U-B staff that had a significant impact in the Walla Walla Valley in 2025.

Patricia Fulton becomes county's first woman Superior Court judge

History was made in 2025 in Walla Walla County when Patricia Fulton, a former defense attorney and court commissioner, became the county's first woman Superior Court judge after being sworn in on Jan. 10.

Fulton ran unopposed in the 2024 general election. Fulton's fellow Superior Court judge, Brandon L. Johnson, presided over the ceremony.

"Since 1893, there have been 16 duly elected (Walla Walla County) Superior Court judges before (Fulton's) election this past November," Johnson said. "There is one common through-line that ties every Walla Walla County Superior Court judge together before today. That is, we have all been white men. I am so honored today to be part of swearing Patty

in as our county's first ever woman Superior Court judge."

Before her election, Fulton was the Superior Court's commissioner, meaning she served as a part-time judicial officer. Now, she's a full-time judge.

"I have received so much support from the community from when I first announced I was going to embark on this," Fulton said after taking her oath at the courthouse. "I promise I will do everything I can to serve the community to the best of my ability."

Brandon O'Neel case ends with guilty plea, 25-year prison sentence

On Oct. 30, Brandon O'Neel, 40, was sentenced to 25 years in prison, the maximum sentence that Walla Walla County Superior Court Judge Brandon L. Johnson was allowed to issue for the shooting of a Washington State Patrol trooper three years earlier.

O'Neel pleaded guilty on Sept. 2 to attempted first-degree murder and attempting to elude police, just six days before he was scheduled to stand trial.

He shot Trooper Dean Atkinson Jr. on Sept. 22, 2022, after O'Neel was evicted from his Walla Walla apartment earlier that day.

After he was shot, Atkinson drove himself to Providence St. Mary Medical Center and was able to walk into the emergency room. He has since returned to duty with WSP.

Atkinson spoke at the sentencing hearing.

"As I drove myself to the hospital, I started to realize the severity of the situation," he said. "I found myself noticing the blood all over my uniform. I started fearing I would not survive. I remember asking hospital staff, 'Please don't let me die.'"



Photo illustration by Zam Ortega, Walla Walla Union-Bulletin file and courtesy art

Patricia Fulton, center, takes the oath to become Walla Walla County's first woman Superior Court judge early 2025; Wa-Hi wrestler Kylie Whitaker, right, brings home the area's first state title of the year; and Blue Mountain Action Council CEO Danielle Garbe Reser, left, speaks to community members during an open house in a few of the top moments from 2025.

Prescott School District faces dissolution

The state assigned a financial oversight committee to Prescott School District early in 2025 because of ongoing financial issues, including unpaid debts and a projected end-of-year negative fund balance.

Although the district cut its budget by \$325,000 this past summer and \$750,000 the year before, the financial situation was found to be worse than previously thought and the district was placed under enhanced financial monitoring in September.

The school now faces dissolution if it does not find enough new revenue — about \$1 million — to cover the costs to pay teachers and meet basic education requirements.

The district, parent-teacher organization and other local groups have spent the past few months fundraising to save the school from closure. The district also plans to seek



Kezia Setyawan, Walla Walla Union-Bulletin file

Dean Atkinson Jr.'s wife, Meagan, reads her comments about her husband's recovery after the September 2022 shooting. On the far right, defendant Brandon O'Neel sits with his head lowered. O'Neel was sentenced on Thursday, Oct. 30.

legislative funding during the upcoming legislative session and ask voters to increase the collection amount on its educational programs and operations levy.

Historic Gem Theatre reopens in Athena

After two decades of planning, volunteer labor and perseverance, Athena's historic Gem Theatre reopened in October as a restored 1920s-style multipurpose theater. Its first feature was "City Girl," a 1928 silent film shot in Athena but never before shown there.

Project manager and Gem Theatre board member Rob McIntyre discovered the film while researching the theater's history and traced its unusual past.

For the premier, composer John F. Paul wrote a new score that was performed live by musicians from the East

Oregon Symphony.

Built in 1901, the Gem operated off and on until 1968 before shuttering. McIntyre and a volunteer group began restoration efforts in 2004, but financial setbacks, the COVID-19 pandemic and health events in the family slowed progress.

With millions in grants and tens of thousands of volunteer hours, many contributed by local students and their parents, the team rebuilt the theater.

The renovation became a multigenerational community effort, offering students mentorship and hands-on experience in construction. Many volunteers worked on the building regularly for years. The result is a venue that's ready to host films, concerts, theater productions and more.

For McIntyre, the reopening is both surreal and deeply meaningful, a

"Field of Dreams" moment after years of dedication.

Whitman College announces layoffs

Whitman College cut 10 staff positions this past summer and reduced the salaries of staff members making more than \$70,000 a year because of a \$3 million budget shortfall.

Whitman College President Sarah Bolton said the budget shortfall could mainly be attributed to a trend of declining enrollment across the country.

Fewer students attending college has led many colleges such as Whitman to offer more scholarships and take less tuition in order to compete with other schools to keep enrollment numbers steady.

Through these tactics, Whitman has managed to keep its enrollment around a steady 1,500, but because

SEE 2025 PAGE 3A



Photo courtesy of Whitman College

The Penrose Library sits at the heart of the Whitman College campus.

Newest member of Walla Walla City Council

Rodney Outlaw takes oath of office before crowd

KATE SMITH
WALLA WALLA UNION-BULLETIN

Rodney Outlaw joined the Walla Walla City Council, taking the oath of office before a crowd of about 50 people on Monday, Dec. 29.

Outlaw, representing the central ward in Position 2, is the only new Walla Walla City Council member in 2026.

"I feel good, I feel supported," Outlaw said after being sworn in. "I wasn't expecting this amount of people, this diverse group of people. It definitely shows me that the community is ready for some change."

He said the gathering, which filled the City Council chambers and spilled into the hallway, felt both joyful and pressure-filled.

"People need to understand what the role of City Council is, and what power a council person might or might not have," he said. "(There's) some pressure of having to remind people of that."

Two current council members, Rick Eskil and Gustavo Reyna, were reelected to their positions in the general election and took their oath of office after the Monday, Dec. 15, work session.

Outlaw's public swearing in with family members and community supporters, was only the second such

oath ceremony, City Clerk Lisa Neissl said, during her time as clerk. There was also a public swearing in for Jeff Robinson after he was elected in 2023.

Outlaw, in his campaign, focused on Walla Walla's youngest generations. He said he wanted to see youth and children's programs recentered downtown and growth that created new jobs and affordable housing for young adults and families.

Outlaw is the founding faculty member of the audio engineering program at Walla Walla Community College. He's also the founder and executive director of the Running Waters Equity Fund, a grant fund intended to disrupt and address systemic inequities, and the president of The Health Center's Board of Directors.

"I think we're in a place where we can bring some, not even differences of opinion, but some different ways to approach things, to the table, right?" he said. "A lot of my conversations are, 'It doesn't have to be one or the other.' I think that's what gets us in trouble in the first place."

The first City Council meeting of 2026 will be a work session on Monday, Jan. 12, followed by a meeting on Wednesday, Jan. 14.



Photos by Kezia Setyawan, Walla Walla Union-Bulletin

Walla Walla City Council Position 2 member Rodney Outlaw shakes hands with City Clerk Lisa Neissl after taking his oath of office on Monday, Dec. 29.

City Council members serve four-year terms. Outlaw, Eskil and Reyna will serve through 2029.

● Kate Smith can be reached at katesmith@wwub.com or 509-577-7709.

Walla Walla City Council Position 2 member Rodney Outlaw smiles for a photo with Whitman College Black Student Union Vice President JaidaMae Robinson after the swearing-in ceremony.



Supporters of Rodney Outlaw take a group photo in the Walla Walla City Council chambers.

SOLUTION TO TODAY'S CROSSWORD PUZZLE

Jan. 1

H	O	O	P	S		P	R	O		T	O	T	E	S
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N	E	S	T	S			I	R	K		F	I	R	M

7-DAY FORECAST FOR WALLA WALLA

TODAY	TONIGHT	THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY	SUNDAY	MONDAY	TUESDAY
Intervals of clouds and sun	Overcast	Cloudy	Mostly cloudy	A couple of afternoon showers	Variable cloudiness	Cloudy	A bit of morning rain
HIGH: 39° RealFeel: 42° Winds: W 3-6 mph	LOW: 26° RealFeel: 27° Winds: SE 3-6 mph	38° 34° RealFeel: 40°/33° Winds: WNW 3-6 mph	43° 40° RealFeel: 45°/37° Winds: VAR 3-6 mph	57° 38° RealFeel: 53°/36° Winds: SSW 7-14 mph	50° 37° RealFeel: 54°/36° Winds: SSW 3-6 mph	47° 38° RealFeel: 49°/39° Winds: SSW 3-6 mph	46° 34° RealFeel: 49°/35° Winds: VAR 2-4 mph

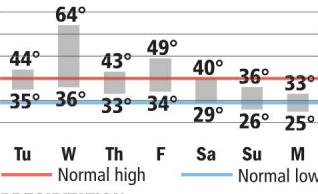
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WALLA WALLA ALMANAC

Statistics through Monday

TEMPERATURES	
High/low	33°/25°
Normal high/low	40°/29°
Last year's high/low	50°/38°
Record high	64° in 1975
Record low	-16° in 1968

LAST WEEK'S TEMPERATURE TREND



PRECIPITATION

Monday	0.00"
Month to date	2.50"
Normal month to date	2.08"
Year to date	14.42"
Last year to date	15.15"
Normal year to date	18.59"

HEATING DEGREE DAYS

Index of energy consumption indicating how many degrees the average temperature was below 65 degrees for the day with negative values counting as zero.

Monday	36
Season to date	1501
Last season to date	1782
Normal season to date	1965

SNOWFALL

Monday	0.0"
Season to date	Trace
Last season to date	0.3"
Normal season to date	3.0"

RELATIVE HUMIDITY

Monday's average	80%
Today's average	70%

WIND

Average direction/speed	S at 3.6 mph
Highest speed	7 mph

BAROMETRIC PRESSURE

Low	30.56" at 12 a.m.
High	30.66" at 2 a.m.

NATIONAL EXTREMES

For the 48 contiguous states Monday

High: 83	Tamiami, FL
Low: -13	Fosston, MN

Forecasts and graphics provided by AccuWeather, Inc. ©2025

REGIONAL FORECAST

Intervals of clouds and sun today. Expect 2-4 hours of sunshine with average relative humidity 65% and poor drying conditions. Overcast tonight. Average relative humidity 80%.

AIR QUALITY INDEX

41 Good

Source: airnow.gov

SUN AND MOON

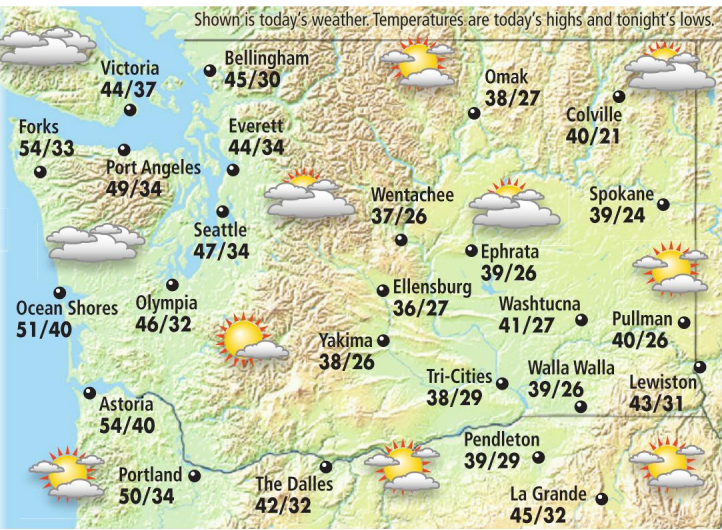
	Today	Thu.
Sunrise	7:35 a.m.	7:35 a.m.
Sunset	4:17 p.m.	4:18 p.m.
Moonrise	1:18 p.m.	2:11 p.m.
Moonsset	4:52 a.m.	6:14 a.m.

WASHINGTON CITIES

City	Today	Thu.
Aberdeen	50/34/c	48/40/r
Bellingham	45/30/c	44/37/c
Colville	40/21/c	41/31/c
Ellensburg	36/27/c	39/32/c
Everett	44/34/c	44/39/r
Moses Lake	39/27/c	40/33/c
Olympia	46/32/c	47/40/r

NATIONAL CITIES

City	Today	Thu.
Albuquerque	54/39/c	56/40/c
Anchorage	7/-1/s	5/-5/s
Atlanta	51/34/s	58/41/s
Baltimore	37/26/c	33/19/c
Billings	50/35/c	46/31/c
Bismarck	21/9/c	28/14/c
Boise	44/32/s	47/41/c
Boston	32/25/c	29/13/c
Casper	46/35/s	46/35/c
Charleston, SC	53/38/s	59/41/s
Charleston, WV	37/22/c	30/20/sf
Charlotte	50/35/s	56/35/s
Cincinnati	31/7/s	21/14/c
Cincinnati	36/22/c	31/23/c
Cleveland	28/15/s	22/17/sf
Dallas	65/44/s	70/56/p
Denver	57/35/s	51/35/c
Des Moines	38/13/c	29/19/c
Detroit	27/9/s	20/17/sf
El Paso	62/47/c	67/47/c



LOCAL CITIES

City	Today	Thu.
Dayton	43/27/c	43/34/c
Elgin, OR	43/28/c	42/35/c
Helix, OR	39/27/c	40/33/c
Kahlotus	40/28/s	40/34/c
Pendleton, OR	39/29/c	41/36/c
Starbuck	42/26/c	42/33/c
Tri-Cities	38/29/c	37/33/c

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